

## FRANCE

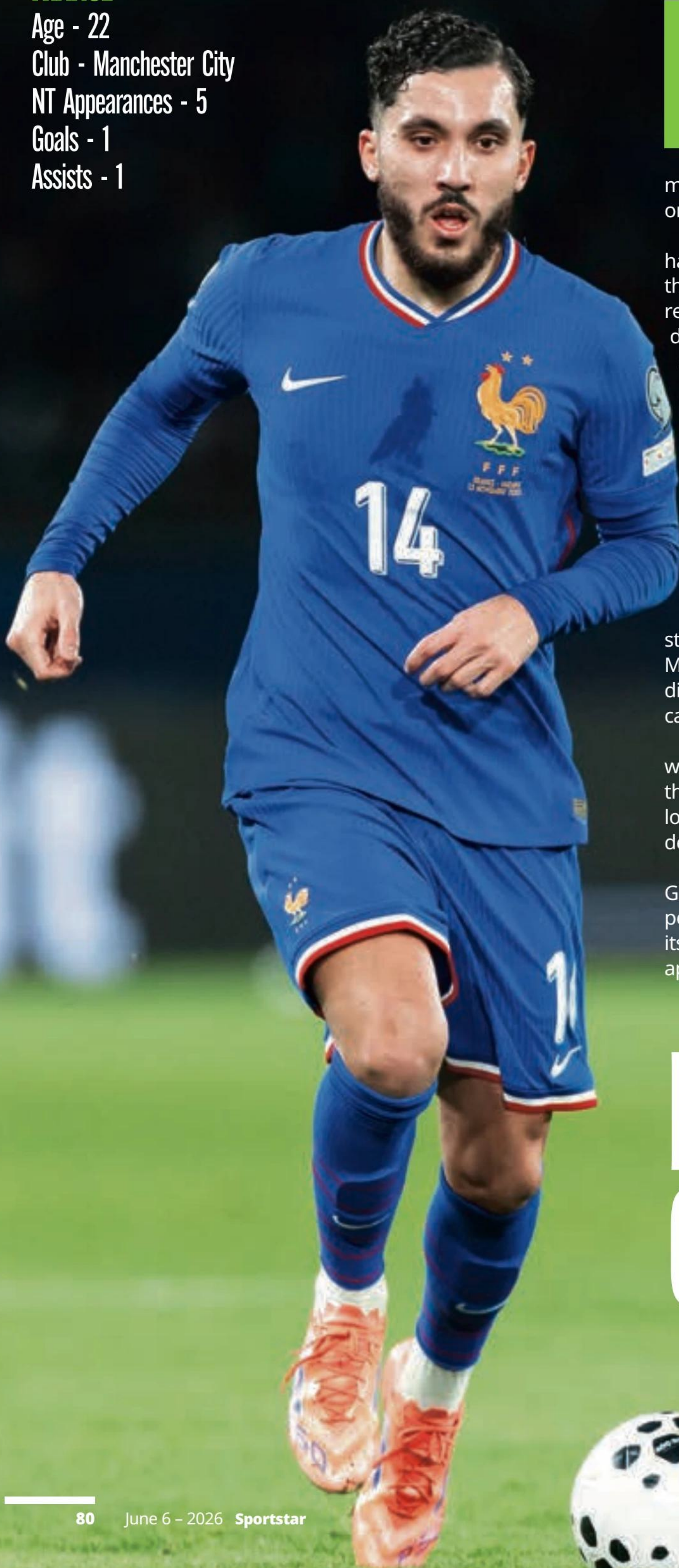
Age - 22

Club - Manchester City

NT Appearances - 5

Goals - 1

Assists - 1



**I**n an era where systems and build-up play have taken precedence, Manchester City's Rayan Cherki has emerged as a breath of fresh air. Despite playing under the stylistically rigid Pep Guardiola, the Frenchman has made a strong impression with his proficiency on the ball.

Unlike many in recent memory who have had their natural style restrained after joining the club, Cherki has more often than not reached into his bag of tricks, from flicks over defences and darting dribbles to the occasional showboating in the middle of the pitch.

Even if the moves don't come off 100 per cent of the time, he has racked up 10 goals, 15 assists and two trophies in his debut season.

However, while he walks into Guardiola's starting lineup at the moment, the national team might prove to be a tougher task. There is no doubt he will be on the plane, but getting minutes in a team stacked with heavyweights like Kylian Mbappe, Michael Olise and Ousmane Dembele could be difficult, especially since he has just five senior caps.

But it is not certain Didier Deschamps' men will always come up against teams that allow them to attack directly, and when faced with a low block, Cherki could be the key that unlocks defences by operating in congested areas.

Especially in the absence of Antoine Griezmann, the two-footed Cherki is the perfect candidate to link France's midfield with its frontline in his first major tournament appearance.

# Rayan Cherki